

In the Line of FIRE

As pro-LTTE political parties and fringe groups come together against the war in Sri Lanka, an ailing Karunanidhi is caught between an island and a hard place

By S. Senthil Kumar

On January 29, 26-year-old Muthu Kumar died in Chennai after he poured a can of petrol on himself and lit a match to set himself ablaze. It was an act of symbolic support for the cause of Tamils in Sri Lanka, but it left the DMK patriarch and Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi in a bind. Walking the political tightrope on the Sri Lankan Tamil issue, the 85-year-old chief minister has in recent years had to balance himself between the pressures exerted by the pro-LTTE fringe groups in the state and the compulsions brought about by being in a political alliance that works both ways: in Delhi, the DMK is part of the ruling UPA, while in Chennai, the support from the Congress keeps the minority DMK in power at the head of an alliance.

Kumar's suicide last week has fuelled the anger of pro-LTTE fringe groups like never before and their ire is aimed at the ruling DMK Government in the state and the UPA Government in the Centre. At Kumar's funeral, the anti-government tirade was at its peak. Hailing Kumar's sacrifice, pro-

**KARUNANIDHI (RIGHT) SAYS
MUKHERJEE'S COLOMBO VISIT WAS
DUE TO HIS PRESSURE (BELOW)**

